

Glossary — The Course Master Method

The terms you'll hear across the five weeks.

- **Decisions document** — A one-page record of the choices only you can make (audience, objective, depth, scope, tone, tools). Written first; everything downstream inherits it.
- **Decisions before production** — The core rule: decide *what* and *how deep* before producing any material.
- **Learning objective** — A statement of what the *student* will be able to *do*, in an observable verb.
- **Bloom's Taxonomy** — Six levels of cognitive demand (Remember → Understand → Apply → Analyze → Evaluate → Create), each with measurable verbs. Used to set the altitude of an objective.
- **Course-level vs. module-level objectives** — Course objectives describe the end of the whole course; module objectives ladder up to them (tagged →CO#).
- **Seven research-based practices** — A design audit: Activate Prior Learning, Organize Knowledge, Motivate, Develop Mastery, Practice & Feedback, Student Development & Climate, Self-Directed Learners.
- **Decompose into modules** — Breaking a subject into right-sized, sequenced modules that fit your available time.
- **Container** — Your course's real schedule (e.g., a 3-hour workshop, a 12-week course), measured in **contact hours**.
- **Contact hours** — An estimate of how long student work takes; used to check a module fits its container ($\text{Hours} = \text{Total} \div \text{Average-per-hour}$).
- **Master Design Document (MDD)** — The single source of truth: a course-header block + one table per module (objectives, topics, materials, activities).
- **The three packages** — Every module ships **Instructor Materials**, **Student Materials**, and a **Teaching Guide**.
- **LLM** — A large language model: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini and the like. When this course says "the AI," that's what it means.
- **System prompt** — The standing instruction you give an AI tool at the start of a project, so you don't retype your context every time. The two councils are written out as system prompts in Guide §10.
- **Altitude** — How high an objective aims on Bloom's ladder: *list* is low, *design* is high. Neither is better; they're for different goals.
- **Gates** — Anything a student must pass before they're allowed to do the next thing. Most courses have none. For safety-critical skills, decide this first — and note **a gate is completion, not a grade**.
- **Scaffolding form** — What your three rungs actually are in your medium: you demonstrate it, then you do one together, then they do one alone.
- **Gradual-release scaffolding** — *I do* → *we do* → *you do*. Support decreases across the course (e.g., complete example → fill-in-the-blank → independent).

- **Hints** — Guidance you leave for students when you're not in the room — a reminder of purpose, never the answer.
- **Minute-by-minute agenda** — A timed Time/Activity/Details plan for a live session, in the teaching guide.
- **Teaching-guide depth (floor vs. gold)** — *Floor*: agenda + talking points. *Gold*: verbatim, fully-scripted segments. Pick the level that makes the course teachable by whoever will teach it (the **portability** test).
- **Depth rule** — Go only as deep as your audience's goal needs; stop where deeper wouldn't help them. Heuristic: keep asking "why" until you'd be comfortable saying "I don't know" to the class.
- **GenAI guardrails** — You decide and verify; AI drafts. It's confidently wrong often enough that you check everything.
- **Feedback envelope** — For work with many valid answers: your axes (the three or four things you'd comment on in any submission) against three bands — strong, typical, off-base — with a real example in each cell. Built *before* anyone submits, so most of your feedback is written in advance. It tells you what to **say**, not what to score.
- **Beat** — One timed sub-block of a segment script. "One slide per beat" means the deck tracks what you actually say, in order.
- **Review Council** — A multi-persona review (SME, student, instructional designer, professor) that scores a *finished* module on consistency, delivery, factuality, and teaching principles before it ships. (Distinct from the competing-interests *design* council you can use while planning.)
- **Threading** — How modules connect: a short intro that links back and a conclusion that pivots forward.
- **Portability** — The real test of a course: could someone else teach it from your materials alone?